Iranian Revolution. Repressed by the PML(N) government between 1997 and 1999, LeJ sought refuge in Taliban-controlled Afghanistan, cultivating its ties with Al Qaeda. It re-emerged in Pakistan in May 2002 by bombing Karachi's Sheraton Hotel, killing fourteen (including eleven French engineers). The LeJ operatives have since conducted prominent anti-state attacks, including the bombing of the Marriott Hotel in September 2008 in Islamabad, the attack on the Sri Lankan Cricket team in March 2009 and the October siege of the GHQ in Rawalpindi.

LeJ was instrumental in the formation of the TTP and increasingly shapes the TTP agenda. This means that sectarian violence is part of the new mix of terror, affecting the Shia populations of KP and FATA. Not only are Shias targeted, non-Deobandi Sunni Muslims such as Barelvis, and Sufis are also targets.

The other Punjab-based group, Jaish-e-Mohammed, along with central Punjab-based Lashkar-e-Tayyaba/Jamaat-ud-Dawa (LeT/JuD), is among Pakistan's most important anti-India oriented jihadist groups and as such quite different from LeJ. However, according to Khaled Ahmed both are linked and united by their sectarian agenda: 'The SSP is the umbrella political group while Jaish-e-Mohammed and Lashkar-e-Jhangvi represented the organisation's [Kashmir] jihadi and domestic militant wings respectively' (International Crisis Group 2016, p. 6).

As mentioned at the start of the chapter and detailed in the dialogue on sectarianism at a private university in Karachi[21] below, the young respondents do see sectarianism as a problem:

> *I think the problem goes as far back as the 1970s.*
>
> *We are proxies of Iran and Saudi Arabia now.*
>
> *There is a way out. We need to stop taking their aid. That way they cannot control us.*
>
> *By the way the Shia-Sunni problem has also reached London. Did you read about how someone wrote Kaafir on a Shia mosque in London?*

Sectarian groups have found their way into mainstream politics. In the 2017 National Assembly by-elections for seat NA-120, a new political party was formed – Milli Muslim League, with a candidate by the name of Muhammad Yaqoob Sheikh (see Figure 4.1), who in 2012 was declared a terrorist for raising funds and operationally supporting the LeT (Hashim 2017a). The emergence of the MML and its links to LeT/JuD is believed to be part of the military's attempt at mainstreaming such militant groups, which became a point of contention between the army and the former prime minister Nawaz Sharif, who was